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BUILDING MAHABHARATA RAG

Simplest possible RAG configuration on the Mahabharata.

I ran it on the Adi Parva. Here's what it exposed.

Here's what happened →

— WHAT I BUILT

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The bare minimum baseline.

- Cleaned up the HTML and extracted the raw text, keeping parva, sub-parva, section and paragraph details
- Fixed 1,000-character chunks with 20% overlap
- A small open embedding model. Top 5 passages by similarity
- An LLM writes a cited answer

No reranking. No query tricks. No framework.

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0.81

Correctness on 24 hand-labelled questions.

It also refused every question the text cannot answer.

A reasonable start, right? But it exposed many things.

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The Adi Parva is a complex form of storytelling.

ONE PERSON, MANY NAMES

Arjuna = Partha = Dhananjaya

ONE NAME, MANY PEOPLE

Parikshit and Parikshita

STORIES INSIDE STORIES

A narrator retelling a lineage ten generations back

ONE LIFE, SCATTERED

Birth, family and deeds in different sections

Know your corpus before you index it. Chunks cannot see any of this, so the information has to be organised first: entity resolution, a knowledge graph, GraphRAG.

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Retrieval was weaker.

Same questions, with the right passages handed over:



The model was not the problem. The answer text reached it in only 67% of questions.

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A good score can hide a weak stage.

I read the passages behind 12 graded answers:

> Right section, wrong paragraph.

> An irrelevant passage ranked #1.

> The key sentence cut off at a chunk boundary: “`And from Drupada wa…`”

Why it matters: when retrieval misses, the model refuses questions it could answer. Karna's father: the passage naming him never reached it.

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Calibrate the judge before you trust it.

1. An LLM judge scored the answers. I graded a sample blind and compared.
2. First round: **67%** agreement on correctness.
3. Causes: name aliases and spelling variants. Fixed one change at a time.
4. Re-tested on fresh answers, then froze the judge.

A judge you have not checked is just another guess.

— WHERE THIS GOES

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Now I have a baseline to beat.

01 Smarter chunking

02 Hybrid search

03 Reranking

04 Query rewriting

05 GraphRAG for lineages

One change at a time, each measured against the same frozen judge.

Starting at a baseline was a good approach. Did you apply strategies directly to your solution, or have you tried it this way?

— NEXT

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Improving it, one change at a time.

What would you try first?

Mahabharata RAG — a baseline-first RAG build over the Adi Parva, measured at every step.

Every post in this series is a real decision or lesson from building it.

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